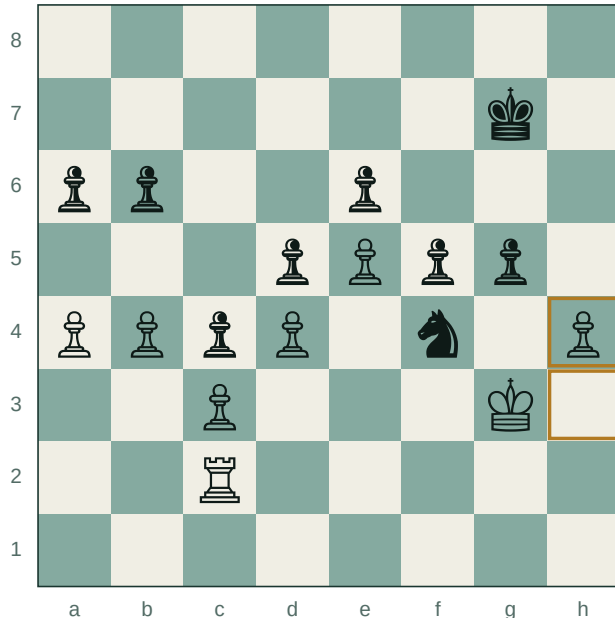


Active defensive resources: Black, move 39

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 39.h4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Nh5+ 40. Kf2 g4

39...Nh5+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **40.Kf2**.

40...g4 The pawn moves from g5 to g4.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -1 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on g3. Geometrically undefended: rook on c2. Check for tactical protection.